

AI TOOLS ASSESSMENT REPORT

Prepared for Maria — Bookkeeping Practice (6-person team, 85 clients)

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1. Executive Summary

Your two biggest time drains, in your own words:

- "I probably spend 10 to 12 hours a week just on email — clients asking the same questions over and over."
- "Every client call I take, I'm trying to take notes while I'm talking and I always miss things... I've made errors because of it."

A close third: you personally chase 15–20 overdue invoices a week by email — "that is not what I went into business to do" — and you rewrite every proposal's scope section from scratch (2 hours each, 6 times a month).

Main outcome to expect: Fewer hours lost to repetitive email replies and post-call note reconstruction, more accurate client records, and invoices that get chased automatically instead of by you. This is the realistic path to getting your evenings back.

Estimated hours reclaimed per week: 10–13 hours, combined across your 6-person team (roughly 3 of those hours are yours directly, from proposals and invoicing). This is comfortably above the 5-hour/week guarantee threshold, so it is not flagged as a risk — but see the Needs Human Review section for how this estimate was built.

Primary focus of this report: Efficiency (time savings) is the dominant lever — 3 of 4 recommended tools exist mainly to give time back. Quality is the strong secondary theme: Fathom directly targets the note-taking errors you described.

2. Effort vs. Impact Matrix

Every opportunity raised in the call, sorted by how much it helps versus how hard it is to stand up:

	LOW EFFORT	HIGH EFFORT
HIGH IMPACT	QUICK WINS• Turn on QuickBooks automatic invoice reminders• Fathom AI meeting notes• Text Blaze snippet library for client FAQs• PandaDoc reusable proposal templates	MAJOR PROJECTS• Client self-serve FAQ / portal tied to real QuickBooks data (due dates, categories) — needs a custom build, not an off-the-shelf tool
LOW IMPACT	EXCLUDED• Generic ChatGPT for one-off client emails — you already tried this; it didn't sound like you and you rewrote it anyway	EXCLUDED• Nothing identified in this call — not padding this out with filler

The four Quick Wins above become the tool recommendations in Section 4. The Major Project is a real opportunity but requires custom work beyond an off-the-shelf tool — see Section 6.

3. Quick Wins Summary

Pain Point	Recommended Tool
15–20 overdue invoices, manually chased by Maria every week	QuickBooks automatic invoice reminders (already included in your QBO plan)

Meeting notes taken while talking — details missed, some client-facing errors	Fathom (AI meeting notes for Zoom)
Team spends 10–12 hrs/week answering the same client questions	Text Blaze (shared team snippet library)
Every proposal's scope section rewritten from scratch — 2 hrs each, 6/month	PandaDoc (reusable proposal templates & content library)

4. Recommended Solutions

QuickBooks Online — Automatic Invoice Reminders

Pain point it solves: "I manually follow up on overdue invoices by email. I have probably 15 to 20 invoices past due at any given time and I'm the one chasing them." This turns on a feature already included in the QuickBooks Online plan you're paying for — no new subscription.

Approx. monthly cost: \$0 (built into your existing QuickBooks Online subscription)

Setup time: About 20 minutes to configure the reminder schedule and email templates

Time saved per week: 1.5–2 hours (your time)

Lever: Efficiency, and Effectiveness (unpaid invoices get chased consistently, which tends to shorten how long they stay unpaid)

Fathom — AI Meeting Notes

Pain point it solves: "Every client call I take, I'm trying to take notes while I'm talking and I always miss things... I've made errors because of it." Fathom joins your Zoom calls, records, transcribes, and writes a summary with action items automatically.

Approx. monthly cost: Free plan available (unlimited recordings/transcripts, limited AI summaries). Team plan for full AI summaries across your 6-person team: \$19/user/month (or \$15/user/month billed annually) — about \$114/month, or \$90/month billed annually.

Setup time: 15–20 minutes to connect your Zoom account; works automatically after that

Time saved per week: 4–5 hours (across the team, from not having to reconstruct or fix notes after each of your 12–15 weekly calls)

Lever: Quality (fewer errors in client records) and Efficiency

Text Blaze — Shared Snippet Library

Pain point it solves: "I probably spend 10 to 12 hours a week just on email — clients asking the same questions over and over... My team is the same way." Text Blaze lets your team save your best, already-written answers as keyboard shortcuts so a full, accurate reply takes seconds instead of a rewrite. Note: this directly addresses what generic AI couldn't — you told us ChatGPT-written emails "didn't sound like me," so Text Blaze uses your own saved wording rather than AI-generated text.

Approx. monthly cost: Business plan (needed for shared team folders): \$8.39/user/month, or \$6.99/user/month billed annually — about \$50/month for your team of 6, or \$42/month billed annually. A free plan (20 snippets, no sharing) exists for testing first.

Setup time: 30 minutes to write your first 5–10 FAQ answers and share the folder with your team

Time saved per week: 4–5 hours (across the team, conservative estimate of cutting repeat-question email time by roughly 40–50%)

Lever: Efficiency

PandaDoc — Reusable Proposal Templates

Pain point it solves: "Every new client proposal I write from scratch. I have a rough template in Word but I have to rewrite the whole scope section every time. Takes me like two hours per proposal." PandaDoc lets you build a reusable content library so scope language, pricing tables, and terms are pulled in, not retyped.

Approx. monthly cost: Starter plan: \$19/user/month billed annually (\$35/month billed monthly) for 1 user (you). Verify current pricing before purchase — PandaDoc's plans and limits change fairly often.

Setup time: 45–60 minutes to load your existing Word template as a reusable content block

Time saved per week: 1–1.5 hours (your time, from ~6 proposals/month)

Lever: Efficiency

5. 4-Day Quick-Start Plan

Start with the tool that costs nothing and gives the fastest relief, then layer in the rest:

Day	Action (5–10 min)
Day 1	In QuickBooks Online, go to Settings > Sales > Reminders and turn on automatic invoice reminders. Set one reminder before the due date and two after (e.g., 3 days before, on due date, 7 days overdue). This immediately starts working on your current 15–20 overdue invoices.
Day 2	Sign up for Fathom's free plan at fathom.ai and connect it to your Zoom account. It will now auto-join your next scheduled client call and produce a transcript and summary.
Day 3	Review the Fathom summary from yesterday's call, then list your team's top 5 repeated client questions (e.g., "when is my report due," "what does this expense category mean"). Write one good answer to each — this becomes your Text Blaze starter library.
Day 4	Create a free Text Blaze account, add your 5 answers as snippets in a shared team folder, and invite your team. Separately, create a PandaDoc account and paste your current Word proposal template in as your first reusable content block.

6. What Comes After Quick Wins

One opportunity from the call is real but doesn't fit an off-the-shelf tool — it's a future engagement, not a hidden upsell:

Client self-serve FAQ / portal tied to your actual QuickBooks data

The reason canned answers only go so far: questions like "when is my report due" or "can you explain this expense category" are client-specific — they need to pull real data from each client's account, not a generic answer. A proper fix is a custom-built client portal or automated lookup tied into QuickBooks, which goes beyond what Text Blaze's saved snippets can do. This would need a scoping conversation of its own — it is not something to bolt on in the next four days.

7. Financial Impact

Formula: (hours saved per week × hourly rate) – total monthly tool cost = net monthly ROI

Hourly rate used: \$50/hour, blended across owner and team time. You did not state an hourly rate on the call, so this is a conservative estimate for a small bookkeeping practice — verify against your actual billable/opportunity cost before relying on this number.

Hours saved per week: ~11 hours (midpoint of the 10–13 hour estimate, combined across the team)

Monthly value of time saved: 11 hrs × 4.33 weeks × \$50/hr ≈ \$2,380/month

Total monthly tool cost: $\approx$ \$150/month (annual billing across Fathom, Text Blaze, and PandaDoc) to $\approx$ \$199/month (month-to-month billing). QuickBooks reminders add \$0.

Estimated net monthly ROI: $\approx$ \$2,180–\$2,230/month, before accounting for any revenue upside from faster-paid invoices or a higher proposal win rate — both plausible but not counted here since they weren't quantified on the call.

8. Needs Human Review

- Hourly rate (\$50/hr): estimated, not stated by the client. Confirm Maria's actual rate (or a blended team rate) before presenting the ROI figure as final.
- Time-saved estimates (per tool and in total): these are professional judgment based on what was described in the call, not measured. Recommend revisiting after 30 days of actual use and adjusting the numbers.
- Pricing for Fathom, Text Blaze, and PandaDoc was verified via web search on July 15, 2026, but SaaS pricing changes often — confirm current plan pricing at checkout before the client commits.
- The client self-serve portal (Section 6) was not scoped, priced, or timed — it needs its own discovery conversation before any commitment is made.
- Team software comfort was rated 4–5/10 by Maria for her staff. The 4-day plan assumes Maria drives setup; a short team walkthrough session may be needed before the whole team adopts Text Blaze and Fathom, which isn't costed here.
- Considered and deliberately excluded: Chaser (dedicated invoice-chasing software) — pricing is revenue-based and not publicly listed, so it couldn't be verified with confidence. QuickBooks' built-in reminders are recommended first; only revisit a paid AR tool if native reminders prove insufficient.